

Escalation Handbook

NovaTech Solutions — Support Operations (Internal)

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1. Purpose & Scope

This handbook defines the escalation framework for the NovaTech customer support organization. It is intended for Tier 1, Tier 2, and Tier 3 support agents, as well as the AI support system's escalation agent. Escalations exist to ensure complex, high-impact, or sensitive issues receive appropriate human attention without unnecessary delays.

2. Escalation Tiers

Tier	Handler	Response SLA	Trigger Conditions
Tier 1	AI Bot / Frontline Agent	< 5 min	General FAQs, password resets, standard billing queries
Tier 2	Specialist Agent	< 4 hours	Unresolved Tier 1 issues, moderate billing disputes, technical errors
Tier 3	Senior Engineer / Billing Lead	< 8 hours	Production outages, data integrity issues, complex billing disputes
Tier 4	Engineering Manager / Finance	< 24 hours	Security incidents, data breaches, legal/compliance issues

3. Escalation Triggers

3.1 Automatic Escalation Criteria

The following conditions must trigger an automatic escalation:

- AI confidence score < 0.5 on any customer query.
- RAG retrieval score < 0.4 (insufficient knowledge base coverage).
- Customer explicitly requests a human agent.
- Intent classified as 'complaint' or urgency classified as 'critical'.
- Same issue reported by the same customer more than twice.
- Any mention of legal action, regulator, or consumer court.

- Suspected fraudulent activity on the account.
- Data loss or data corruption reported.

3.2 Manual Escalation Criteria (Agent Judgment)

- Customer is highly distressed or abusive (escalate to senior for de-escalation).
- Resolution requires access to systems not available to Tier 1.
- Policy exception required (refund beyond standard window).
- VIP or enterprise customer with active contract.

4. Escalation Process

4.1 Required Information for Escalation Ticket

Field	Description	Mandatory
Customer Account ID	Unique account identifier	Yes
Session / Ticket ID	Current support session ID	Yes
Issue Summary	2–3 sentence description of the problem	Yes
Steps Taken	What was already attempted to resolve	Yes
Escalation Reason	Specific trigger (see Section 3.1)	Yes
Customer Sentiment	Calm / Frustrated / Angry / Threatening	Yes
Priority Level	Low / Medium / High / Critical	Yes
Supporting Evidence	Screenshots, error codes, logs	Recommended

4.2 Escalation Notification

Upon ticket creation, automatic notifications are sent to:

- The assigned team's Slack channel (#support-escalations).
- The customer via email confirming a human agent will follow up.
- The daily escalation dashboard for operations tracking.

5. Priority Levels

Priority	Definition	Examples	Target Resolution
Critical	Business-stopping issue	Service down, data loss	< 2 hours
High	Major feature broken	API failures, login blocked	< 4 hours
Medium	Partial service degradation	Slow performance, billing error	< 8 hours
Low	Minor issue, workaround exists	UI bug, question	< 24 hours

6. De-escalation Guidelines

When handling an escalated customer:

- Acknowledge the frustration first — do not jump straight to solutions.
- Use the customer's name, not 'Sir/Ma'am'.
- Summarize the issue back to demonstrate you have read the history.
- Set clear expectations: 'I will have an update for you by 4:00 PM IST today.'
- Follow up exactly when promised — even if there is no update yet.
- Offer goodwill credit for high-effort resolutions when appropriate.